

Market Research

Aggregate Findings

Phase 1 covered five candidate ideas: Travel, Transportation/Educational, Music, Service (a freelance marketplace), and Organization/Quality of Life. We ran five interviews per idea, 25 interviews total, each following our Guided Interview Sheet, with mom test like questions and followups.

Two patterns showed up in every idea. People described workarounds stitched from disconnected tools (Google Maps, notes apps, spreadsheets, sticky notes, Canvas, group chats) rather than one product that handled the whole job. And trust or cost transparency came up unprompted almost everywhere we asked, from choosing a plumber to finding a bus stop to planning a trip.

Two ideas produced the clearest, most specific pain: Travel and Service. Travel subjects consistently described stress around deciding where to go and preparing for it. One said, “I typically plan a lot of things to the minute, and I’ve had issues where we are late because we spend a long time somewhere.” Another described breaking down on the highway and being overcharged for a tire. Service subjects consistently raised trust. One said, “Someone I can trust has experience and won’t overcharge me. No prices over the phone is a red flag.” Another said, “Usually if they don’t show their work, it’s a sign.”

Transportation/Educational, Music, and Organization/Quality of Life surfaced real but narrower problems, detailed below under what we pivoted from. None matched the intensity or specificity we heard about Travel and Service, so those two moved into Phase 2.

Top Pick, Deep Dive: Travel Planner

Phase 2 ran 25 more interviews split between Travel Planner and Freelance Marketplace only, using more curated Mom Test questions: how do you decide where to go on a trip, how do you budget for it, and (for the freelance side) how would you decide which plumber to call.

Travel Planner held up, nearly every subject described the same three step process: pick a destination based on time, group, and interest, check hotel, gas, food, and activity costs, then adjust as new information comes in. Several called that adjustment step stressful and manual. One subject, describing how they plan around what their group wants, said they “used notes to plan itinerary, added as we planned, moved things to group by proximity, then ran the plan by Claude for feasibility and adjustments.” Another described the same

pressure from the other side, “I typically plan a lot of things to the minute, and we’ve had issues where we are late because we spend a long time somewhere.”

Budgeting showed the same fragmentation we saw in Phase 1. Subjects split costs with friends, saved a set amount per paycheck, or pooled money for a family trip, but almost none used a single tool to track it. One frequent international traveler said they wished their tour company had spent more time helping them learn about the places they visited, and separately said they were never sure what to bring or wear. Another described breaking down between San Antonio and Houston, being overcharged for a tire, and going roughly three hundred dollars over budget on gas alone.

Subjects gave us the takeaway in their own words without being asked to summarize, “Seeing if you have planned enough or grouped things too close is a real problem” and “Road trips can have unexpected expenses and interruptions.” That is the specific, repeatable problem Travel Planner solves: helping someone plan realistically and adjust when the trip does not go the way it was scheduled.

What Didn’t Work / What We Pivoted From

Freelance Marketplace was our other Phase 2 finalist, and it stayed strong on trust but weaker on repeatability. Subjects converged on the same signals (reviews, friend recommendations, upfront pricing, photos of past work), but most already had a working method for finding a professional even when it took time. One subject said quality of work, customer service, and speed mattered most, but added they would pick someone they had used before over searching again. That told us the frustration was real but not strong enough to pull people away from habits like calling around, checking Google reviews, or most commonly asking friends. Travel Planner’s pain point, the planning and adjustment step, was something people actively wanted help with in the moment, not just a preference for a slightly better process. That difference is why Travel Planner became our final pick.

We also set aside Transportation/Educational, Music, and Organization/Quality of Life after Phase 1. Transportation’s core problem, not knowing your stop or how transfers work, was real but narrow: more of a one time learning curve than a recurring pain. Music split our interview pool almost evenly between people who already had a friend group built around shared taste and people who were simply too shy to reach out, which pointed to a social confidence problem more than a product gap. Organization/Quality of Life subjects described scattered systems across Canvas, phone calendars, and notes apps, but the underlying behavior (checking several places, forgetting to update one of them) did not point to a single clear feature we could build around. None of the three held up against the specificity we got from Travel and Service, so we did not carry them into Phase 2.